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Research Proposal
on
Investigating How Children Interpret “Self-Made” and “Collective” Narratives of Success Through *Fish Out of Water*: A Paired-Script Picture Book Study in Children’s Residential Shelters in Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam
(Ages 8–12)

Full Legal Name: Dung Tan Nguyen

38 **Institution:** Le Hong Phong High School For The Gifted, Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam

Category: Junior

Class/Grade/Year: Grade 12

Country: Vietnam

Submission Date: September 20, 2026

Registered Email Address: uniartist0806@gmail.com

Research Topic: Investigating How Children Interpret “Self-Made” and “Collective” Narratives of Success Through *Fish Out of Water*: A Paired-Script Picture Book Study in Children’s Residential Shelters in Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam (Ages 8–12)

Introduction: Anthropologist Clyde Kluckhohn wrote that "it would hardly be fish who discovered the existence of water" [1]. Children raised inside family support resemble those fish: the help that carries them is so constant that it becomes invisible, which is why the belief that success is self-made feels natural. Sociologists document how large and how quiet that help is, showing that families underwrite children's schooling, housing, and first steps into work long past the teenage years [2]. Children in residential care sit outside this water. Their support is institutional, shared among many peers, and it usually ends in the mid-to-late teens, when they leave care without the family backing most young people keep [3], [4], [5]. Yet the story of success set before them, told in picture books, in classrooms, and in the individualist culture of post-reform urban Vietnam, is the same self-reliant one addressed to everyone else [6], [7]. This study names that mismatch the script-support gap: children are asked to aspire through a story that quietly presumes the support they most lack. UNICEF Viet Nam reports "an estimated 156,000 children are without parental care and an estimated 33,000 children live in institutions" [8], while the UN Committee on the Rights of the Child has urged Vietnam to widen family and community based alternatives [9]. What no one has yet asked is how these children themselves read that story.

To address this gap, this study develops ***Fish Out of Water:*** a children's picture book and research device built around a fish who leaves the water to pursue his love for making music. The illustrations and plot remain constant and varies only four to six framing sentences, so that one version credits the fish's success to his own effort *(tự mình)* and the other to doing it together *(cùng nhau)*. The study's central argument is that the self-made story is believable only from inside the support it hides, so children who grow up outside that support become its most revealing readers [10], [11], [12]. The present study comes at a timely moment, as Vietnam reorganizes child welfare under a 2025 restructuring that moved social protection to the Ministry of Health [13]. The research does not aim to be a portrait of every child in care, but to produce a low-cost, repeatable pilot model to hear how these particular readers make meaning.

Research Questions: Using Fish Out of Water, this study aims to investigate how children in residential care interpret stories of success from their own social position. Central research question: How do children aged 8-12 growing up in residential care in Ho Chi Minh City interpret "self-made" versus "collective" tellings of the same story of success, and what do their interpretations reveal about how their social position shapes which futures feel possible?

In this respect, the study addresses the following sub-questions:

1. Recognition: Which telling do children find more believable and more like their own lives, and why?
2. Attribution: To whom do children give credit for the fish's success, and which parts of their own social world (caregivers, peers, teachers, money, shelter rules) do they use to explain it?
3. Navigation: Whom do children place around themselves when imagining their own goals, and how does this compare with the futures caregivers say the shelter encourages?
4. Device: Do children register the contrast between the two tellings, and how do children and caregivers rate the book's clarity, appeal, cultural fit, and emotional safety?

Literature Review: Children in residential care lead highly relational lives, forming large peer networks even as they negotiate disruption around identity and belonging [3]. Research on

leaving care shows their transition to adulthood is compressed and that outcomes hinge on sustained relationships [4]. Reviews of this field increasingly argue that interdependence, not independence, is what protects care leavers [14]. Sociology has long treated stories as cultural scripts and repertoires that organize action and distribute worth unevenly across groups [15], [16], [17]. Work on meritocratic belief shows that self-made framings lead people to read outcomes as individually deserved [18]. Children's books likewise often center a lone, self-reliant hero [7], [19], while reception research argues that meaning depends on the reader's social position [20]. Scholars of childhood insist that children are competent interpreters of their own worlds, which is why this study treats them as readers rather than as cases at risk [12], [21], [22].

Three mechanisms connect these strands. Recognition operates when a story mirrors the reader's world, so believability and "like me" judgments can be observed directly [17], [20]. Attribution operates when a reader assigns credit, so the framing sentences and attribution cards reveal whom the child holds responsible [18]. Navigation operates when aspiration becomes a map of helpers, so a "who would be with you?" task shows the people a child expects to rely on [23], [24].

In Vietnam, the self-made script has gained ground among urban youth since the *Đổi Mới*[1] reforms, alongside a professional middle class that prizes individual achievement [6], and moral and citizenship education transmits value scripts to children early [25]. Recent qualitative work finds that Vietnamese care leavers rely heavily on external support and meet stigma as they approach adulthood [5], while domestic research on children in care has centered on mental health and risk rather than on how they read culture [26]. Elsewhere, studies of primary-school children find that young people hold conflicting repertoires about success, invoking personal merit even when they perceive structural inequality [27].

These bodies of work point toward one integrated design: treat success as a script that distributes worth, hold that script constant in the pictures while varying only who receives credit, and read children in care as capable interpreters [12], [15], [17]. They also flag hazards the book must manage, including children's tendency toward adult-pleasing answers, the double meaning of a title that can signal not belonging, the limits of small samples, and the ethics of research in care settings, each of which shapes the design below. To our knowledge, no study has used a paired two-script picture book that holds illustrations and plot constant while varying only the framing of success as self-made or collective, to observe how children in residential care read the same success story. This study therefore, takes up that gap by building Fish Out of Water as both book and device and by centering the children's own readings.

Proposed Methodology: This research uses a convergent mixed-method reception study built around a paired-script picture book, where a reception study asks how readers make meaning from a text rather than whether the text improves them [20]. We combine children's ratings with their own words and drawings, because the numbers show whether readings differ across the two tellings while the talk and pictures show why [28]. The paired-script design draws on the vignette technique and on story-completion methods, which vary one detail of a shared story to surface the meanings readers bring to it [29], [30], [31].

1. **Development of Fish Out of Water:** We will develop the book into four steps before any fieldwork begins.

[1] Đổi Mới ("Renovation") refers to Vietnam's economic and social reform process initiated in 1986, which shifted the country toward a socialist-oriented market economy.

1.1. We will have one story in two versions that share identical illustrations and plot, differing only in 4-6 framing sentences.
1.2. Version A will credit the fish's success to his own effort (tự mình), written as self-reliance and never as being left alone. Version B will credit it to doing it together with others (cùng nhau). The two versions will have the same number of pages and sentences and a word count within five words of each other, so that only the framing differs.
1.3. A panel of two primary-school teachers, one shelter social worker or caregiver, and one children's author or illustrator will rate each version on a four-point rubric for clarity, cultural fit, and emotional safety. We will revise any page that receives a score below 3 from any reviewer.
1.4. We will pilot the book with 6–8 children (3–4 per version) from a shelter outside the main sample. We will proceed only if at least three in every four children answer the understanding check in line with their version; otherwise, we will sharpen the framing sentences and pilot again.

2. **Participants and Sampling:** The sample consists of children aged 8-12 living in residential shelters in Ho Chi Minh City. We aim to recruit between 48 and 60 children across 4-6 shelters, with a fallback of 32 to 40 children across 3 shelters, and we will also interview 4-5 caregivers. Using purposive sampling, we will include children who have lived in the shelter for at least six months, fall within the age band, and can follow a read-aloud story in Vietnamese; caregivers may exclude any child they judge likely to be upset by the activity. The 8-12 band is chosen because these children can rate, explain, and draw, yet still engage readily with picture books. For the qualitative strand, the sample size follows the principle of information power rather than statistical power, given the study's focused aim [32]. For the quantitative strand, about 25-30 children per version is enough to show only large differences between the two tellings, which is why we treat the numbers as exploratory. Within each shelter, children will form reading groups of 4-6, balanced by age and gender, and each group will be randomly assigned to Version A or Version B.

3. **Study Procedure and Timeline:** The project will run for 16 weeks: four for developing and piloting the book, eight for fieldwork, and four for analysis and reporting. In each shelter, both tellings will be read on the same day, in separate rooms, by the same reader following the same script.
3.1. Baseline: Before the reading, each child will answer a few background questions (age, gender, time in the shelter) and mark a simple ladder showing where they expect to stand in the future. This step lets us check that the two groups are similar before they hear the story.
3.2. The reader will read the assigned version aloud to each group.
3.3. Post-activity Data Collection: After the reading, each child will complete a draw-and-tell task and retell the story in their own words [33]. Each child will then complete a "who would be with you?" name generator, a simple prompt that asks the child to name the people who would help with a chosen goal [34], together with the picture-card questions and smiley-face ratings of the book [35].

Each child will also answer the understanding check privately ("Did the fish succeed mostly by himself or mostly with others?").

3.4. Group Discussion: A short group discussion will close the session. It comes last so that children's individual answers are not shaped by what others say.

3.5. Caregiver Interviews: Caregivers will take part in fifteen-minute interviews about the futures the shelter encourages and will rate the book on the four-point rubric.

4. **Measurement tools:** We will use short, child-friendly tools, each adapted from an established method. Because they are new in this form, the pilot (1.4) will check that children understand them.

4.1. Attribution Cards: Each child will choose one of three picture cards to show who made the fish's success happen (the fish alone, the fish and others, or others), a format adapted from the vignette technique [29], [30].

4.2. Smiley-face Ratings: Five-point smiley-face scales will record how believable the story is ("Could this really happen?") and how close it feels ("Is the fish like you?") [35].

4.3. Name Generator: We will count how many helpers each child names and who they are (caregiver, peer, teacher, relative, other, or nobody), as a simple indicator of social capital [34].

4.4. Futures: At baseline, each child will say what they hope to do and what they think they will really do when they grow up, and will mark a Cantril-style ladder adapted from a version validated with adolescents [36].

4.5. Drawing Codebook: A written codebook will record who appears in each drawing and whether the fish and the child are alone or with others. Two independent coders will apply it, and we will report their agreement with Cohen's kappa, a standard measure of agreement beyond chance [37].

4.6. Acceptability: Children will rate the book with smiley faces, and caregivers and the review panel will rate its clarity, appeal, cultural fit, and emotional safety on the four-point rubric.

4.7. Qualitative Data: Recorded retellings, children's explanations of their drawings, group discussions, caregiver interviews, and observer notes.

5. **Data Analysis:** We will first analyze the numbers and the children’s words separately and then bring them together:

Quantitative Analysis: We will first check that the two groups were similar at baseline. We will then report frequencies and medians for every measure. Fisher's exact test will compare attribution-card choices and drawing codes across the two versions, with Cramér's V as the effect size. The Mann–Whitney U test will compare smiley-face ratings and the number of helpers named, with rank-biserial correlations and 95% confidence intervals. Acceptability ratings will be summarized as mean scores per criterion. We treat all tests as exploratory, because the sample is small and children are grouped within reading groups and shelters.

Qualitative Analysis: Retellings, group discussions, and caregiver interviews will be transcribed in Vietnamese and analyzed with reflexive thematic analysis [38], [39]. We

will compare themes across the two tellings and across shelters in a comparison matrix, and we will read the drawings for who is present and where the child places the self.

Triangulation: Finally, we will place each numerical pattern beside the children's words and drawings in joint displays [28], organized by sub-question, and note where the two streams agree or diverge. A reflexive journal and an audit trail will allow each conclusion to be traced back to evidence.

6. **Ethical Considerations:** We will obtain written permission from each shelter's director or legal guardian, in line with Vietnam's Law on Children [40], rather than parental consent, and every child gives assent and may stop at any time. A familiar caregiver stays nearby, questions concern only the story and never a child's own past, and no deception is used. We will follow a distress plan, anonymize all drawings and quotations, and seek review through the student's school and mentor, guided by established standards for ethical research with children [41]. The title is always framed as finding one's place, never as not belonging.

Expected Outcome: We anticipate that the two tellings will be read differently across recognition, attribution, and navigation, and that children will explain their readings by drawing on their own social world in the shelter. The prediction is deliberately two-sided. If children find the collective telling more believable and fill their futures with named helpers, this would suggest that life in care is teaching interdependence. If they embrace the self-made telling while naming few helpers, this would suggest that the independence message has been absorbed without the support it assumes. The study will also show whether Fish Out of Water works as a device, that is, whether children register the contrast and rate the book as clear, appealing, culturally fitting, and emotionally safe.

Potential Limitation: The sample is small and drawn from a few Ho Chi Minh City shelters, so the findings will describe these settings in depth but cannot speak for all children in care in Vietnam. In addition, the tools are new and not yet validated in Vietnamese, children may give answers they think adults want, and we are both the authors and the evaluators of the book. The pilot, the indirect drawing tasks, and an independent second coder are included to reduce these risks.

Conclusion: Fish Out of Water offers a practical, low-cost way to hear how children in care read the stories of success addressed to them. By pairing one story with two tellings, the study aims to reveal both the limits of the self-made script and the map of helpers these children can actually count on. As a small pilot, it aims to open this question, not to settle it.

Project Practicalities: We will coordinate with each participating shelter to schedule the readings around the children's routines. The main costs are printing both versions and art materials, and the team will include a trained co-observer, a second coder, and a school mentor.

Post-program Plan: We will refine Fish Out of Water using the children's own readings and leave a final edition and a short reading guide with the participating shelters. We also plan a follow-up reading with children living with their families, and we will seek partnerships with child-protection NGOs and children's publishers so the book can reach other shelters.

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